AI-POWERED DATA ANALYSIS REPORT

Volunteering and NGO Engagement in India

Understanding the trends, what the data tells us, and how NGOs can engage volunteers

Prepared by	Area
Sabith Mohammed V	Civil society & volunteering

1. Introduction

For this task, I studied how volunteering and NGO engagement are changing in India, with some attention to Kerala. Volunteers help NGOs deliver programmes, bring in skills and often become long-term supporters. However, volunteering is not equally strong everywhere, and many programmes find it hard to keep volunteers motivated and supported. I used the findings from my own research notes, which draw on sources such as Goodera's volunteering reports, a Bain & Company sector estimate and a global review of community health volunteers, to understand the main trends and what NGOs can do with them.

2. Key findings from the research

The figures below show that volunteering in India is relatively strong, and that most NGOs already work with volunteers.

31%	22%	~70%	20–50%
Of Indian workers volunteered in 2024	Global benchmark for workers who volunteer	Of Indian nonprofits actively engage volunteers	Of some NGO budgets later raised by former volunteers*

*Reported by some NGOs in India; it does not apply to every organisation. Worker volunteering figures come from Goodera reports, as cited in my research notes.

Employee volunteer participation rate

The small-firm figure comes from a separate Goodera VQ finding, so the groups may not be exactly comparable. Treat it as an indication.

3. Key trends

- **Younger volunteers prefer flexible roles.** Short-term, skill-based and virtual volunteering is growing. Platforms such as Catchafire and Goodera match professionals with NGO projects.
- **Companies are driving volunteering.** India's CSR rule (large firms spend about 2% of profits, roughly $2–3B a year) has supported employee volunteering programmes, and companies now treat volunteering as part of staff development.
- **Volunteers are becoming donors.** NGOs such as Team Everest, Claylab and Bhumi report that well-engaged volunteers often turn into fundraisers and long-term donors.
- **Kerala shows strong community-led volunteering.** Examples include the 2018 flood response, Haritha Karma Sena (waste management) and Kites Foundation, which supported 23 volunteer-led projects in 2022. Kerala-specific volunteering data is still limited.

4. What I learned from the data

- **India is above the global benchmark.** At 31% against 22%, the share of Indian workers who volunteered is 9 percentage points higher, which gives NGOs a good base to build on.
- **Interest is not the same as impact.** Many past programmes were tokenistic. Volunteers who are given meaningful roles, such as helping design a programme, stay longer and help the mission more.
- **Retention is the weak point.** In a global review of health volunteer programmes, attrition ranged from 9% to 53%, and up to 77% in some programmes. These figures come from health programmes, so they are an indication for NGOs rather than a rule.
- **Most NGOs are small.** About 91% have budgets under Rs 10 crore, so low-cost ways of training and supporting volunteers matter.

Main insight: Volunteering is not only about how many people are willing to help. It is about whether NGOs give volunteers meaningful roles, flexible options and support, so that one-time helpers become long-term contributors and donors.

5. Challenges and possible solutions

The solutions below are suggestions based on the research. They are not outcomes measured in the sources.

Challenge	What NGOs and community partners could do
Tokenistic roles Volunteers are used only for simple tasks.	Involve volunteers in programme design, give clear roles with real responsibility, and match tasks to their skills.
Burnout and attrition Health volunteer programmes lost 9–53% of volunteers, and up to 77% in some.	Provide training, recognition or small incentives, social support and wellbeing check-ins. Avoid relying on unpaid people for vital work indefinitely.
Changing volunteer expectations Younger people prefer short-term, skill-based or virtual roles.	Offer flexible options such as one-day events, online mentoring and skill-based projects, with a clear path to longer commitment.
Safeguarding and ethics Volunteers often work with children and other vulnerable groups.	Use codes of conduct, background checks, child-protection training and a grievance process.
Limited measurement and data Few NGOs track volunteer outcomes, and Kerala-specific data is scarce.	Record hours, skills built and retention, and share simple results openly so other NGOs can learn from them.

6. How an NGO can check whether its volunteer programme is working

A volunteer programme should be reviewed regularly. An NGO could track a small set of indicators, such as the number of volunteers recruited, the share who continue after a set period, the hours contributed, the skills volunteers say they gained, how many volunteers later donate or fundraise, and how supported volunteers feel. A short feedback survey at the start and end of each project can show whether volunteers felt their time was well used.

7. Conclusion

This research helped me understand that volunteering is a strong but under-used resource for NGOs. India already has high participation, and companies, young people and local communities, including those in Kerala, are all contributing. The challenge is to keep volunteers engaged through meaningful roles, flexible options, training and care. NGOs that do this can turn volunteers into long-term supporters, and better data would help show what really works.

8. References

Sources as listed in my research notes:

1. Goodera, volunteering reports and the Goodera VQ report (employee volunteering rates in India and globally, 2024).
2. Bain & Company, estimate of India's social sector funding (2024).
3. India Development Review (IDR), analysis of volunteering and voluntarism in India.
4. Global scoping review of community health volunteer attrition and sustainability.
5. Companies Act 2013 (amended 2019), CSR rules for large companies in India.
6. Reports on Kerala organisations: Kites Foundation, Captains Social Foundation and Haritha Karma Sena.

9. Originality and AI-use declaration

This report was drafted from my research notes with the help of Claude, an AI assistant, which was used as a support tool to organise the information and structure the report. The statistics and research findings are credited to their original sources listed above. The suggested actions are interpretations of the research, not measured outcomes. I have not intentionally included copied or unattributed material.

Note: This declaration describes the preparation process; it is not a certified plagiarism-check result. Similarity scores can only be assessed using an appropriate plagiarism detection service.